me the ancient painted side eye.

The 100 ft-tall Chorten, about the same height as a modern 10-storey building, is quiet and unexpected, sitting like lost luggage in the middle of the woods. But it draws thousands of visitors during the yearly Gorzam Kora festival. It is said that Monpa monk Lama Pradhar carved in a radish a model of the Boudha Stupa in Kathmandu, and replicated the stupa in Zemithang to banish bad luck.

The Monpas, culturally and ethnically close to Tibet, are one of Arunachal Pradesh's 26 main tribes; there are over 100 sub-tribes. The people of this state—the northernmost and easternmost of India's northeastern states—are tucked into fold upon fold of densely-forested mountains and great river valleys, ranging from tropical plains to heights that will freeze one's face off. No wonder the tribes are so diverse, each with its own attire, dialect, dance, and

REYOM ETE'S FAMILY COOKS US A FULL DINNER FROM SCRATCH—CHICKEN, GREEN LEAFY VEGETABLES, MOUNTAINS OF RICE, BEER AND MORE APONG. ARUNACHALIS SEEM TO FIND THE SIGHT OF AN EMPTY GLASS IN A GUEST'S HAND INTOLERABLE

opinions about other tribes. But they all open their hearts to visitors.

Rewind nine days and 1,370 km to West Siang district, the middle of the state (I've joined the convoy four days in, missing Rima and Miao villages. However, I was also on the first Trans-Arunachal Drive in 2021, and so, I have seen other places in the east, including Dong, where the rising sun first strikes Indian territory).

The people of Kambu village take us into their thatched homes, only recently connected to the world via a steel footbridge over the Siyom river. Imagine twilight on



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With world-class highways and blacktop, the roads in Arunachal can put many of Delhi's to shame